

Post pandemic, how has the travel and tours industry picked up in general and in particular for Smiley Trips?

We see a strong and growing will to travel by Indians, particularly, to newer and exotic destinations. Their bucket list is filled to the brim with locales for happiness and relief. For Smileytrips.com, our focus has been to customize the experience through our App. The online space has grown to a stage where it is now the preferred source to book travel itineraries and so we are positioned strongly in this space.

The recent decade or two has witnessed manifold increase in demand for travel and tour arrangements. How is Smiley leveraging this indulgence as a robust interface between travel industry and customers?

With the increase in travel by Indians and the world being in their palm, thanks to high speed network on their phones, we understood from the beginning that we need to give the customer the experience of customizing each and every item of their travel. Our App is developed based on this focus.

Which are the most popular travel segments, both in-bound and out-bound and the new emerging trends?

A very tough question, but our observation is that it's come to a stage that the seasoned traveler has seen the world and wants rich and meaningful experiences. They are repeating to locales they covered 10 years back for nostalgia. Cruise holidays

are still a niche market.

One important component is the health of the traveler, particularly, senior citizens. Do you intend to have tie-ups with hospitals/clinics as back-up for emergencies as an added facility in you tour and travel package offerings other than insurance?

As a matter of fact the insurance covers almost all aspects of emergency health needs while travelling. However when senior citizens travel, we design the program to be less strenuous. We are in the process of tie-ups with health care providers in countries where we have our own branch.

For seamless management of itineraries, how are you using technology for optimizing efficiency?

People are searching and booking through their mobiles. Travelers are now trusting their phones, and now they expect to be able to rely on all their planning and booking on just one device. Smileytrips.com has been working to make this experience user friendly and with focus to have maximum flexibility and customization. Our App is just the right thing for the now and future travelers.

What expansion plans do you have in the pipeline, which are off-beat and different from the tried and tested destinations?

We have branches in India, Europe, Sri Lanka and Thailand. From the traditional growth view point we are in the process of

having offices in every country preferred by travelers. We are also identifying destinations that are yet to be popular and try to bring them into focus for our customers. Our focus is not only the Indian traveler but anybody in the world who wants to travel and see the World.

In the next five years what is your estimation of the growth of tour and travel industry?

We expect growth to be in the in the double digits on year to year basis.

Do you intend to start an institution exclusively for teaching and training of the travel, tour and hospitality industry, considering that there is shortfall in trained manpower?

Well, there are institutions which cater to this segment. Smileytrips.com focus has been towards automation and technology in the travel space.

With over 15 years in the industry, what have been the learnings and experiences that you would like to share with the readers and those aspiring to venture into this industry?

When we started, information flow was from us to the customer. Now the information and details that the client has is extraordinary. There is an overflow of information on the web. I would like to inform our readers and request them - please support the travel services company, yes, we are available in the online space, but our operations team will interact with you and give relevant information to make your holiday a better experience.

What best explains Smiley Trips in a tag-line?

Smileytrips.com- India vin no.1 tour operator!

